

MAKING A POINT Jan Suraaj convenor Prashant Kishor at a public meeting in Patna, Aug. 4

ANI

- **The 10-yr 'PK Plan': radically transform infra, education and healthcare, stop the need for migration**
- **To break the grip of entrenched powers, he has to persuade voters to go beyond caste, community old party loyalties**
- **As a Brahmin, caste is also his weak link. To mute critics, he has an open model of revolving leadership**

DURING HIS 2-YEAR PADAYATRA ACROSS 5,300+ VILLAGES, HE TOLD ORDINARY BIHARIS THAT BY VOTING "BASED ON CASTE, RELIGION", THEY WERE RESPONSIBLE FOR BIHAR'S PLIGHT

disenchantment that birthed the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) experiment, with a mode, temper and method decidedly urban. Jan Suraaj literally means 'People's Good Governance'. Can this language of corporate efficiency work in a state whose very political grammar is woven around caste? PK is confident. After a two-year-long padayatra that touched over 5,300 villages, listening to the "aspirations and frustrations" of ordinary people, he feels Bihar is ready for a disruptor like him.

Even if his canvas is long-term, Prashant Kishor's immediate impact will be the existing field of play. For some three decades, Bihar has largely been a duopoly shared by two political estates—the Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) of Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, and the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) lineage running from patriarch Lalu Prasad Yadav to his son Tejashwi. Add to that the increasing ingress made by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), and it becomes an unstable tango of three. As things stand, all three have reason to see themselves as having a fair shot at power when Bihar votes next. And thus, to feel ambivalent about the arrival of Prashant Kishor, with his potentially pan-Bihar appeal. But who he impacts more is a question for later. Right now is the time for platform visibility: the party's launch and the attendant national media spotlight, which PK is stirring as if to the manner born.

Bihar First

"It's good that you've come. This is for Bihar." His refrain to the gathering in the lawn echoes his stated ambition—to challenge the entrenched powers and "change the system" in his home state. "I am looking at the next 10 years," he asserts. In the thousands of interactions he held during his padayatra, Prashant confronted his audiences with a stark message: that by voting "based on caste, religion, short-term gains, or out of fear", they themselves are responsible for Bihar's plight. "Laluji has been a good father; he's thinking about making his son the CM of Bihar. Have you ever thought about what your children will do?" Prashant would ask. After two years of this grassroots evangelism, the momentum he has garnered can be quantified. Even before its launch, Jan Suraaj's membership has swelled to over 6 million. "People have had enough of the bits-and-pieces politicians with their blinkered visions and parochial goals," he says. "They have been voting for Lalu because they feared the BJP, or for Nitish and the BJP because they feared Lalu. We want to give them an option to think beyond them."

PK has authored many campaign scripts, but this mission is different—it's personal, it's home. He speaks of a Bihar where education, healthcare,